This chapter covers the period from 1959 through the 1962 Sino-Indian war. It looks at the impact of the China-India race on the US-India relationship in 1959. It then considers the deteriorating Sino-Indian relationship that year, how it was seen in Washington, the interest it generated in Delhi in assessing Sino-Soviet relations, American hopes that it would ease India-Pakistan relations, and the opening it created for US-India defense cooperation. The next section considers how the Kennedy administration saw India in relation to China, as well as the concerns it had about Indian stances on particular global issues and how the Nehru government managed those differences given their need for the US vis-à-vis China. It considers the growing Indian concerns about China, as well as the developing China-Pakistan relationship, and Indian efforts to seek military equipment from abroad. It then considers the road to the Sino-Indian war, US assistance to India during that war, and whether or not India jettisoned nonalignment in the process.

Ike Likes India; India Likes Ike (1959–1960)

In April 1959, an official testifying in Congress noted that he did not even need to outline why India's success was so crucial for the noncommunist world since that fact had already been so well established. Growing Chinese economic strength, another testified, meant that the US had to help India compete.[8] Outside government, influential economists like Walt Rostow and Max Millikan and columnists like Walter Lippmann made a similar case, arguing that India could show the way in Asia or go the way of China.[9]

That spring, Senators John Sherman Cooper (R-KY) and John F. Kennedy (D-MA) introduced a resolution that called for sending a team to study Indian requirements. This time they couched it in terms of South Asia to pre-empt the previous year's criticism about too much focus on one country. At a May conference on India and the US, Vice President Nixon and Senator Kennedy spoke out vociferously in support of aid for India—each, as Merrill notes, vying "for recognition as India's best friend." Nixon asserted, "What happens in India … could be as important or could be even more important in the long run, than what happens in the negotiations with